(Link: www.nhs.uk/)

Whiplash

Whiplash is a neck injury caused by sudden movement of the head. It usually gets better within 2 to 3 months, but some people may have symptoms for longer.

Symptoms of whiplash

Whiplash most often happens after a traffic accident or a slip or fall. Other common causes include a slip or fall, and sports injuries.

Common symptoms of whiplash include:

- neck pain (Link: www.nhs.uk/symptoms/neck-pain-and-stiff-neck/)
- neck stiffness and difficulty moving your head
- headaches
- pain and muscle spasms in the shoulders and arms

It can take several hours for the symptoms to start after you injure your neck.

Things you can do to treat whiplash

There are some things you can do to treat whiplash.

Do

- ✓ take painkillers, such as paracetamol (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/paracetamol-for-adults/) or ibuprofen (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/ibuprofen-for-adults/), to help with pain
- ✓ try to continue doing everyday activities – it might hurt a little but it will speed up your recovery

Don’t

- ✗ do not use a neck brace or collar to support your neck – this does not help
- ✗ do not rest your neck for long periods of time

When and where to get medical help

A GP can help if symptoms of whiplash are not getting better. Some symptoms need urgent medical help.

See a GP if:

- symptoms of whiplash have not improved after 1 week
- painkillers like paracetamol or ibuprofen have not worked
- you're worried about the pain

Refer yourself for back or joint help

In many areas you may be able to get help, such as physiotherapy, from NHS community musculoskeletal (MSK) services without needing a referral from a GP.

Get NHS help for back or joint problems (Link: www.nhs.uk/nhs-services/get-nhs-help-for-back-joint-problems/)

Ask for an urgent GP appointment or get help from NHS 111 if:

You have injured your neck and:

- you have severe pain despite taking paracetamol or ibuprofen
- you have tingling or pins and needles on 1 or both sides of your body
- you have problems with walking or sitting upright
- you have a sudden "electric shock" feeling in your neck and back which may also go into your arms and legs
- your hands, arms or legs feel weak

These symptoms could be caused by damage to the nerves in your neck or back. Do not do anything that could be dangerous, such as driving or cycling, until you have spoken to a GP or NHS 111.

You can call 111 or get help from 111 online (Link: https://111.nhs.uk/triage/check-your-symptoms).

Treatment for whiplash

A GP may prescribe a stronger painkiller such as codeine (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/codeine/) for whiplash.

You should have check-ups with a GP every few weeks if you have whiplash. If your symptoms do not get any better, they may refer you:

- to a physiotherapist
- to a pain specialist
- for psychological support

Physiotherapy (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/physiotherapy/) from the NHS may not be available in your area and waiting times can be long. You can also get physiotherapy privately.

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